Lessons We Learn as Women

By Amanda Lovelace, Clementine von Radics and Sierra DeMulder

Some Destruction is Beautiful by Amanda Lovelace

The ground --
it ignites
wherever
a woman's
foot
comes down

& if
you're not
careful,

the
very same
thing
could
happen
to you
--some destruction is beautiful

4NG Fanatics

SOURCE INFORMATION

Author: Amanda Lovelace
Book: The Witch Doesn't Burn in This One
ISBN: 978-1449489427
Publisher: Andrews McMeel Publishing
Date (Month/Year): March 2018

INTRODUCTION

No woman's experience is universal, yet the world somehow manages to teach women universal lessons. The world teaches women how to pretend. I have done it many times. I have done it when I have wanted to say something but decided that it would be too "unladylike" or too aggressive or come from my mouth as a female. And so I have let many things go, and have kept quiet. I have silenced my voice for the sole reason that I am female. Today, my voice will be heard along with the voices of Amanda Lovelace, Clementine von Radics and Sierra De Mulder in this collection of poetry I call Lessons we Learn as Women.

Paper Dolls by Sierra DeMulder

We are taught
from the moment we leave our pink nurseries
we are collapsible paper dolls:
light to hold, easier to crumple.
That as women, our worth lives secretly

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wrapped in lace and cotton panties,
our fragility armored in pepper spray and mace.
They say one in three women will be raped
or sexually abused in their lifetime.
I am one of three daughters.
Imagine each victim is an acrobat.
Her sanity, a balancing act.
Our response is the unfailing safety net.
We never expect to see her across the wire.
You weren't just violated, we tell her,
you are an empty museum, a gutted monument
to what used to hold so much worth.
With best intentions we tell her to reclaim it,
put a price tag on her rape and own it.
Don't stand too tall, don't act too strong.
We will name you *denial*.
Come back when you are ready to crumble
like your bones are made of chalk.
You can only laugh cutely or cry beautifully,
so cry beautifully.
We will catch you.

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We are calling it theft,
as if he could pluck open your ribs like cello strings,
pocket your breasts, steal what makes your heart
flutter
and tack its wings to his wall.
Some days you will feel dirty.
Some weeks you'll remember how hard it is to breathe in
public,
but know this:
the person who did this to you is broken. Not you.
The person who did this to you is out there,
choking on the glass of his chest.
It is a windshield
and his heartbeat is a baseball bat:
regret this, regret this.
Nothing was stolen from you.
Your body is not a hand-me-down.
There is nothing that sits inside you holding your worth,
no locket that can be seen or touched,
fucked from your stomach to be left on concrete.
I know it's hard to feel perfect

when you can't tell an Adam's apple from a fist.

Some ashtray of a man picked you to play his Eden

but I will not watch you collapse.

SOURCE INFORMATION

Author: Sierra DeMulder
Book: The Bones Below
ISBN: 978-0984251537
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INTRODUCTION

The 2nd lesson the world teaches women is to always see themselves through the eyes of men. If you're too loud, the world says no man will put up with that. If you're too quiet, men will be bored. Women can't be too intelligent, or men will keep their distance. Women can't be too much of anything. But they can't be lacking in anything either. While men just strive to be decent, the world expects women to strive to be perfect. But you know what? Women can be loud, quiet, intelligent, strong and self-assured. This is the lesson we as women must teach our daughters . . . And let the teachings of the world be stilled.

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For Teenage Girls with Wild Ambitions and Trembling Hearts by Clementine von Radics

[Anne Frank . . .]

When you are 13 years old,

the heat will be turned up too high

and the stars will not be in your favor.

You will hide behind a bookcase

with your family and everything left behind.

You will pour an ocean into a diary.

When they find you, you will be nothing

but a spark above a burning bush,

still, tell them

Despite everything, I really believe people are good at heart.

[Joan of Arc . . .]

When you are 14,

a voice will call you to greatness.

When the doubters call you crazy, do not listen.

They don't know the sound

of their own God's whisper. Use your armor,

use your sword, use your two good hands.
Do not let their doubting
drown out the sound of your own heartbeat.
You are the Maid of Untamed Patriotism.
Born to lead armies into victory and unite a nation
like a broken heart.

[Malala . . .]
When you are 15, you will be punished
for learning too proudly. A man
will climb onto your school bus and insist
your sisters name you enemy.
When you do not hide,
he will point his gun at your temple
and fire three times. Three years later,
in an ocean of words, with no apologies,
you will stand before the leaders of the world
and tell them your country is burning.

[Mary Shelley . . .]
When you are 16 years old,

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you will invent science fiction.
The story of a man named Frankenstein
and his creation. Soon after you will learn
that little girls with big ideas are more terrifying
than monsters, but don't worry.
You will be remembered long after
they have put down their torches.

[Jackie Mitchell . . .]
When you are 17 years old,
you will strike out Babe Ruth and Lou Gehrig
one right after the other.
Men will be afraid of the lightening
in your fingertips. A few days later
you will be fired from the major leagues
because "Girls are too delicate to play baseball"

[Sacajawea . . .]
You will turn 18 with a baby on your back
leading Lewis and Clark
across North America.

[Cleopatra . . .]
You will turn 18
and become queen of the Nile.

[Nelly Bly . . .]
You will turn 18
and bring justice to journalism.

[For Teenage Girls with Wild Ambitions and Trembling Hearts . . .]
You are now 18, standing on the precipice,
trembling before your own greatness.

This is your call to leap.

There will always being those
who say you are too young and delicate
to make anything happen for yourself.
They don't see the part of you that smolders.
Don't let their doubting drown out the sound
of your own heartbeat.

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You are the first drop of a hurricane.
Your bravery builds beyond you. You are needed
by all the little girls still living in secret,
writing oceans made of monsters and
throwing like lightening.

You don't need to grow up to find greatness.
You are stronger than the world has ever believed you to be.
The world laid out before you to set on fire.
All you have to do
is burn.

SOURCE INFORMATION

Author: Clementine von Radics
ISBN: 978-1449479701
Publisher: Andrews McMeel Publishing
Date (Month/Year): April 2016

But I Owe Something to Myself Too by Amanda Lovelace

this is
an overdue
love letter
to each
& every
woman
who walked
these fields
before me
&
made
the path
soft enough
for me to
walk through
to get to
the side
they could
never reach.
for that,
I owe you
so much.
--but I owe some things to myself, too.

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AWARD HISTORY

MN State Qualifier

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